friendliness to the US and its subscribing to its strategic obligations. Subject to these criteria, the US government has made it explicit that its arms sales policy would not suffer any limitations and that arms transfers to friends and allies complement US security commitment and serve important political objectives. The US on its part has made it known that its policy of economic assistance to third world nations will be linked to US political and foreign policy objectives. Even food aid is made conditional on these factors. Such a linkage will spill into the third world the rivalries and tensions of the big powers and is a negative factor. The international situation both economic and political in our region is made worse by military conflicts. In such an environment, while we need to exercise moderation and keep our options towards various possible developments open, we must, in the final analysis, depend on our own political, military and economic strength while making sure that the demands on our security do not gather from more than one front at a time.

An MEA note said that in 1982, the Indian government was a little cautious about openly supporting the Tamil cause.

A minor, if sometimes intense, irritant has been the demand of Sri Lankan Tamils for Tamil Eelam—a separate Tamil state in Sri Lanka. Though the

moderate Tamil leadership, led by the TULF, has been willing to go along with Jayewardene's reforms to usher in greater regional autonomy, the hardline Tamils have taken the view that they should fight for a separate state. The government of India's position on this question has been unequivocal. We have scrupulously treated this as an internal problem for Sri Lanka to resolve. In view of the recent political agitation within Tamil